

does it slid down. HP D5368 put up consistent performance across the tests and delivers printout with acceptable time limits.

Coming to print quality, HP's D5368 sets the benchmark for others to follow. Be it text, graphics or photographs this printer delivers exceptional printouts which are faithful reproductions of their original. The tonal balance was spot on with no over saturation seen in any colour. Finer details were also perfectly rendered. Canon's iP-3500 comes in at second place here displacing the Epson Stylus C110 to third place. Epson's C110 does good job of reproducing the text and graphics, but looses out on tonal balance especially in the graphics test. Otherwise it is as good as Canon's iP3500.

If you want the cheapest and basic printer for printing nothing but documents then Epson's Stylus T11 should be in your list. HP 910, Canon iP2580, Epson Stylus C110 and Canon iP3500 are good printers, but nothing quite beats HP Photosmart D5368. It has all the features you can ask from a printer and is versatile at doing many things, plus the pricing is just perfect. We suggest HP's PhotoSmart D5368 as the ultimate Home/SoHo printer and give it the *Best Buy* as well as the *Editor's Pick* award.

## Photo Printers

In this category we have grouped together photo printers from HP, Canon, and Epson. Though termed as photo printers they can also be used for general purpose printing too. Canon's iP-4500, Epson's R230 and R290 and HP's PS D7268 were the contenders here.



## Features

On paper, HP's D7268 has an impressive list of features for a Photo printer. It has a small touch sensitive LCD panel which allows the printer to be used for printing photographs without a PC. The inbuilt memory card reader helps in this matter too. The printer is PictBridge compliant and hence digital cameras can be directly connected to it. It comes with a separate tray for printing directly on a CD/DVD. The D7268 has inbuilt Ethernet and can be connected directly using the USB 2.0 interface. The only thing missing is dual side printing.

Canon's iP-4500 comes from the same PIXMA series but has features which defines it as a photo printer. Unlike HP it doesn't have any LCD panel or memory card reader, but is PictBridge compliant and can also print to CD/DVD directly. It has dual-paper path and the combined capacity equals 300 sheets. The iP-4500 also offer auto dual side printing.

Epson's R290 and R230 are from the same series; R230 is an old model. While the R230 sported contoured design, the R290 is boxy, but appealing. Both these printers are positioned by Epson as photo printer based on the fact that they use more than three ink cartridges to improve colour gamut. But none of the features present in HP or Canon

is made available here, which is a serious drawback for both these printers.

## Performance

You guessed it right! Canon's iP-4500 simply blows the competition away when it comes to printing speed. It retains its speed advantage across the various tests we put it through. Be it text, graphics, photographs or large files it just prints them instantly.

HP D7268 and Epson R290 are neck and neck returning similar timing at least in the text document test. In the graphics and photograph test HP surges ahead of the R290 which takes more time to complete the job. The Epson R230 gets left behind in almost all the tests. We thought it would be because its an older model and competing with the latest would always be a challenge.

In the print quality test, HP's D7268 and Canon's iP-4500 were lugging it out. Both these printers were exceptional in printing text and on par with each other. But in the combi-document, the finer differences between the two started appearing. Finer details were amicably reproduced by both printers. Canon has a slight advantage in the colour gamut test and was able to reproduce all colour and their gradients. In the photograph test, it was HP's D7268 who took the lead by reproducing a flawless photograph. The tonal accuracy was superb and the photograph came out stunning. Canon's printout was near as good but the photograph had a warm tone to it. Epson's R230 and R290 did reproduce good prints but their performance was completely overshadowed by HP and Canon's performance.

If you are looking at an affordable photo printer then HP's PhotoSmart D7268 is better equipped in terms of features to handle your needs. The Epson printers are too basic and the Canon iP4500 does deliver great results but doesn't have the feature list HP's D7268 offers. For this very reason we give the HP PhotoSmart D7268 our Best Buy award. ■

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HP Photosmart D7268

## Contact Sheet

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